education’. Ever the master tactician, the old man struck while the Soviet ambassador Abrasimov – an ally of Honecker – was in Moscow. For a brief, tantalising moment, it looked like Honecker was finished. Reportedly, none of the Politburo uttered a sound either during or after Ulbricht’s speech.

After he’d hurried out of the room, a flummoxed Honecker appeared at the Soviet Embassy on Unter den Linden. His voice choked and broke as he pleaded with Abrasimov’s personal assistant to place a long-distance call to his boss in Moscow. The transcript of that torturous conversation, reads in part:

Yes, you know, Pyotr Andreyevich, Honecker is sitting in your study at the moment. He is completely desperate and depressed. He says that there was a meeting of the Politburo at which it was decided to relieve him of the post of second secretary of the SED and to send him to party school. Honecker asks you, Pyotr Andreyevich, to inform the leadership of our party about this.

14

That evening, by all accounts, there was a great deal of toing and froing of messages before Brezhnev dispatched Abrasimov back to Germany. On arriving at Ulbricht’s summerhouse, red-eyed from staying up all night, he was treated to a lecture on Honecker’s morally wayward conduct and poverty of imagination. His arguments fell on stony ground and after being continually interrupted by Abrasimov, Ulbricht was told to reinstate his deputy in what proved a watershed moment for SED politics. The action strengthened an emerging anti-Ulbricht faction that included Kurt Hager, Horst Sindermann and Willi Stoph.

Honecker now delighted in mocking Ulbricht. Having recovered from his ordeal, he received encouragement from Brezhnev on 28 July during a brief